

MISSTEPS? CM Shivraj Chouhan's poll wagon in Bhopal, Jun. 29

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that it improved its tally in the tier 2 and tier 3 bodies where it won a vast majority of seats. But how did the party, which has historically had a strong presence in urban areas, lose key mayoral contests? Also, how will the outcome impact the urban area seats in the assembly election, especially since they make up around a third of the 230 seats in MP?

Political watchers suggest that the BJP botched up the ticket distribution in the municipal corporations. In Jabalpur, Congress candidate Jagat Bahadur Annu, "a people's man" who has risen to the top through the exacting municipal politics channel, was a favourite from the start. In contrast, the BJP candidate seemed to have been thrust down from the top. In Gwalior, intense squabbling marked the ticket choices with the Scindia and Tomar groups pulling in different directions. Interestingly, the person who delivered Gwalior to the Congress after five decades—Congress MLA Satish Sikarwar, whose wife Shobha won the seat—is an import from the BJP. Rewa seems to have gone to the Congress owing to the 'neglect' of the region in representation in the cabinet.

The saffron party's famed election machinery went missing during the polls. Its much-touted booth-level strategy too was clearly not working, especially in BJP strongholds like Bhopal, which were marked by low polling. On polling

KARNATAKA

TWO FACES TO PICK FROM

By Ajay Sukumaran

It's a fuss over a very public birthday bash. Starting this week, Congress leaders in Karnataka are planning to hold celebratory events in various cities in the state as a run-up to a grand public rally in August. The occasion? Siddaramaiah, former chief minister and Leader of Opposition in the assembly, turns 75.

The rally planned for the Congress leader's birthday on August 3 in the central Karnataka town of Davanagere has been in the news for the past couple of weeks. Firstly, its organisers want to make it a big show—about five lakh people from various parts of the state are expected to attend. But more significantly, it had piqued curiosity as to how other prominent leaders–chiefly D.K. Shivakumar, who heads the Karnataka Pradesh Congress Committee—would respond to

THE RALLY TO MARK SIDDARAMAIAH'S BIRTHDAY HAS BOILED DOWN TO HIS APPARENT RIVALRY WITH SHIVAKUMAR

